

Did You Know...? Sports Expressions Hiding in Everyday English

Name: _____

Date: _____

The pattern

Lots of everyday English expressions started life on a sports field and now mean something completely different, with no sport in sight. Horse riding, in particular, has given English an enormous number of these – because for most of English history, horses weren't a hobby, they were transport, work, and war. Tennis has contributed a handful. Basketball, being a much younger and more specifically American sport (invented in 1891), has contributed fewer – most of its slang hasn't fully "escaped" into general English yet.

Horse riding – by far the richest source

Expression	General meaning	Example
hold your horses	wait, be patient	"Hold your horses, I'm not ready yet!"
horsing around	playing around, being silly	"Stop horsing around and finish your homework."
a dark horse	someone with hidden talent, an unexpected contender	"Nobody expected her to win – she was a real dark horse."
straight from the horse's mouth	from a reliable, first-hand source	"I heard it straight from the horse's mouth – he's leaving the team."
get back in the saddle	resume an activity after a break	"After the injury, he's finally back in the saddle."
a one-horse town	a small, boring place	"There's nothing to do here, it's a one-horse town."
put the cart before the horse	do things in the wrong order	"You're putting the cart before the horse – decide the budget before booking the venue."
get off your high horse	stop being arrogant	"Get off your high horse and just apologise."
a leg up		

Expression	General meaning	Example
	help getting started, an advantage	"His uncle gave him a leg up in the industry."
rein in	control, hold back	"The manager had to rein in his spending."
free rein	complete freedom to act	"She was given free rein to redesign the project."
champing at the bit	very eager, impatient to start	"The kids were champing at the bit to get outside."

(A few of these – "leg up," "rein in," "free rein" – literally come from horse riding equipment and technique: a "leg up" is the boost you give someone to help them mount; reins are, of course, what you hold and loosen.)

Tennis - fewer, but very much alive

Expression	General meaning	Example
the ball is in your court	it's your turn to act or decide	"I've sent my offer – the ball's in your court now."
to ace (something)	to do something perfectly	"She aced the exam."
game, set, match	something is decisively finished/won	"Once they scored the third goal, it was game, set, match."

(Fun fact, though the origin is debated: the "love" used for zero in tennis scoring is sometimes said to come from the French word for egg, "l'oeuf," because an egg looks like a zero – but the theory isn't universally accepted by linguists, so treat it as "the story goes..." rather than fact.)

Basketball - the newest sport, the fewest idioms (so far)

Expression	General meaning	Example
a slam dunk	something certain to succeed, an obvious win	"Getting her on the team was a slam dunk decision."
a full-court press	an intense, all-out effort	"The company launched a full-court press to win the client back."

Your example, "playing ball," is actually baseball, not basketball – "play ball!" is the umpire's call to start a baseball game, and "play ball with someone" (meaning to cooperate) comes from there. Worth using as a small trap question in the activity below.

Activity: Sort the expressions

Give students the expressions (without the "sport" column) mixed up, and ask them to sort into three columns: **Horse riding, Tennis, Basketball** – plus a fourth column, **Not one of our three sports**, for any trick entries you add (like "play ball," or a football one like "score an own goal" if you want to raise the stakes).

Follow-up speaking task: in pairs, students pick 3 expressions and use each in a sentence about their own life (school, family, friends) – not sport at all. Good way to check the figurative meaning has actually landed, not just the sport-related one.

Given the imbalance, this naturally becomes a nice discussion point too: why do you think horse riding produced so many more expressions than basketball? (Age of the sport, how central horses used to be to daily life vs. basketball being a recent, specialised game.)

Written exercises (10 min)

A. Fill in the idiom

Complete each sentence with the correct idiom from the box.

Word bank: *hold your horses* · *a dark horse* · *get off your high horse* · *the ball is in your court* · *a slam dunk* · *game, set, match*

1. "_____! I'm not ready yet."
2. Nobody expected her to win – she was a real _____.
3. I've sent my offer, so _____ now.
4. Getting her on the team was _____ decision.
5. Once they scored the third goal, it was _____.
6. Stop being so arrogant and _____.

B. Sort the expressions - table

Sort these idioms into the correct column: *horsing around* · *the ball is in your court* · *a full-court press* · *a dark horse* · *to ace (something)* · *a one-horse town*

Horse riding	Tennis	Basketball

C. Short writing

Pick 2 idioms from this page and write one sentence for each about your own life (not sport).

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About this activity

Standalone "fun fact" piece, ~10-15 min – works as a filler or a wind-down after the sports activities

A. Fill in the idiom

1. Hold your horses 2. dark horse 3. the ball's in your court 4. a slam dunk 5. game, set, match 6. get off your high horse

B. Sort the expressions - table

1. Horse riding – horsing around, a dark horse, a one-horse town · Tennis – the ball is in your court, to ace (something) · Basketball – a full-court press